Agroverse — DTC Paid Acquisition Brief

For: Hubert Yee (Growth / Performance Marketing / User Acquisition) **From:** Gary Teh, Agroverse / TrueSight DAO **Date:** June 5, 2026 **Status:** Final — for discussion with Hubert

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1. Why we're asking for your time

Agroverse sells ceremonial cacao. To date we've grown almost entirely through in-person channels — retail partners, festivals, ceremony circles. We now have hard evidence that customers will buy and **re-buy online, direct, with no face-to-face contact**, and we believe there's an opportunity to open a paid digital acquisition channel (DTC e-commerce).

Nobody on the team has run performance marketing at your level. Before we spend a dollar on ads, we want your expert read on **what the shape of the process should be** — how to structure the test, what to measure, what it takes to set the process up properly — so we don't learn expensive lessons that are already well-known to practitioners.

Sections 2–5 lay out the context and the numbers behind it; Section 6 has the specific questions.

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2. Where Agroverse stands today (refresher)

- **Product:** Single-estate cacao, sourced direct from family farms in Bahia and Pará, Brazil. We're going down the **single-estate / vintage route** — like wine, every year is a new vintage, from the same farm or a newly onboarded one, so the catalog naturally refreshes each harvest and bags are inherently limited-run. Flagship SKU: **ceremonial-grade 200 g bag, retails at USD $25**. Newly launched: **single-estate 50 g chocolate bars at USD $10** — first production run (40+ bars) **completely sold out**. Secondary SKUs: caramelized cacao beans, cacao tea. The portfolio is widening beyond ceremonial cacao; ceremonial is the wedge, not the ceiling.
- **Mission mechanics:** Agroverse is the commerce arm of TrueSight DAO. Every bag and bar funds Amazon rainforest regeneration — one unit → one tree financed, and every unit carries a **QR code that traces back to the actual farm and shipment ledger** it came from. The entire supply chain is publicly ledgered (18 managed shipment / program ledgers to date, AGL0–AGL15 plus program funds).
- **The QR is also a commerce + retention surface, not just provenance:** during online events, attendees scan the QR to buy on the spot; after purchase, customers register their email (if not already registered) to receive **updates on their tree being planted**. Every sale therefore feeds a zero-party email list with a built-in reason to open — a remarketing asset most CPG brands have to manufacture.
- **Store:** agroverse.shop — static site + Stripe checkout. No app. Orders ship from a San Francisco warehouse.

- **Distribution today:** ~37 retail partners (apothecaries, metaphysical shops, wellness venues, co-working spaces) mostly on the US West Coast, largely on consignment; plus festivals, cacao ceremonies, and events run by partners.
- **Brand:** Provenance and verifiable impact are the differentiation. We are deliberately *not* a commodity chocolate brand; the story (farm → ledger → tree) is the product.

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3. The signal that triggered this brief

3a. Customers re-order online, unprompted

A customer in **Shoreline, WA** (acquired in person at events run by our Ashland, OR partner Kelly Springer / Love Wisdom Power) has now ordered twice from agroverse.shop, entirely self-served:

Order date	Items	Subtotal	Total (incl. shipping)
Dec 25, 2025	2× ceremonial cacao 200 g + 1× caramelized beans 200 g	$75.00	$83.58
May 29, 2026	2× ceremonial cacao 200 g	$50.00	$58.61

That's a **~5-month reorder cycle on a multi-bag basket —** implying a consumption rate of roughly **1 bag every 1.5 months** for an engaged practitioner. If that rate holds, a retained customer is worth roughly **$200/year in revenue** (≈8 bags), with zero incremental acquisition cost after the first order.

3b. Zero-touch onboarding works

Our newest retail partner (The Way Home Shop, Portland, OR) was acquired entirely over email: cold outreach Apr 24 → consignment terms agreed Apr 26 → 10 bags shipped Apr 28 → on the shop floor Apr 29 → first commission statement and payment May 13. **No in-person visit at any point.** The product, story, and packaging sell themselves when they reach the right person.

Together: the demand exists beyond arm's reach of our in-person presence, and the funnel (site → Stripe → fulfillment → repeat) already works. What we've never done is **pour paid traffic into the top of it**.

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4. Unit economics & where the ad budget comes from

Ceremonial cacao (200 g bag):

Lever	Value
Retail price	$25.00
Retailer commission baked into that price	~$8.00/bag (actual: $7.50 at our newest partner)
Consignment cost price to retailers	$17.00/bag (shipping included)
Observed DTC basket	2–3 bags, $50–75 subtotal, customer pays shipping (~$8.60)

Lever	Value
Observed reorder cycle	~5 months on a multi-bag basket (~1 bag/1.5 months consumed)

Chocolate bar (50 g, new):

Lever	Value
Retail price	$10.00
Cost price to us (incl. tree planting)	$6.00
Gross margin	$4.00/bar (40%)
First run (40+ bars)	Sold out

The core arbitrage on the bags: **on a DTC sale, the ~$8/bag that would have gone to a retailer is unspent**. On an observed 2–3 bag basket that's **$16–24 of first-order margin headroom available for CAC** — before counting repeat purchases. If the Shoreline pattern generalizes (~$200/yr per retained customer), the LTV-justifiable CAC is meaningfully higher than the first-order headroom alone.

The $10 bar adds a second shape: a **low-friction, impulse-priced entry offer** (sold out on its first run) that plants a tree, captures an email for tree-planting updates, and creates a natural upsell path into the $25 ceremonial bag — potentially a better paid-ads landing offer than asking cold traffic for a $25+ first purchase.

We don't yet know our blended margins well enough to commit to a target CAC/ROAS — that's one of the things we want your help framing (Section 6).

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5. Audience & competitive observations

- **Who buys:** ceremony facilitators, breathwork/yoga/meditation practitioners, apothecary customers, conscious-consumption households. Observed at festivals: skews 35–65, values-driven, **heavily on Facebook** (and Instagram); not a TikTok-first demographic.
- **Competitors:** ceremonial cacao brands (e.g. the larger Keith's/Ora tier of the market) are **buying Google ads heavily** on ceremonial-cacao search terms. Search volume for the category exists and is being monetized — currently without us. Detail below.
- **Our edge in creative:** real farms, real farmers, real trees, QR-verifiable impact, and an existing library of farm photography/video from Bahia. The story is filmable and ownable.

5a. Competitive landscape (from our Feb–Apr 2026 research)

We ran a structured competitor study (Playwright site crawls + DataForSEO keyword export; full reports in this repo under `ceremonial_cacao_seo/` and `output/dataforseo/`). The ad-relevant findings:

Top 5 US ceremonial-cacao competitors — what's driving their sales:

Brand	Platform	Subscription	Free-ship threshold	Wholesale	Amazon presence
Ceremonial Cacao / Ora Cacao (ceremonial-cacao.com)	Shopify	✓	$95	✓	None found
Four Visions	BigCommerce	✓	—	—	None found
Ma Cacao (Portland, OR)	Shopify	—	$100	✓ (+ stockists page)	None found
Bar and Cocoa (curated retailer)	Shopify	✓	—	✓	None found
Maya Moon Cacao	Shopify	—	—	✓	None found

- **Ora Cacao is the category leader** and the one to study: claims “1 million cups sipped each year,” runs subscribe-&-save, a $95 free-shipping threshold, and messaging that overlaps ours almost word-for-word (“directly traded with small organic family farms,” “ethical, regenerative, organic”). They source from Belize / Colombia / Guatemala / Tanzania / Uganda — multi- origin blends, **not single-estate vintages**, and **no per-unit tree planting or on-pack provenance QR**. That’s the daylight between us.
- **Nobody in the top 5 is on Amazon marketplace** — the whole category is own-site Shopify DTC. The paid-traffic battle is fought on search + social, not marketplace shelf placement.
- **3 of 5 run subscriptions** — the category has trained customers to expect a replenishment offer, which matters for the LTV side of any CAC math (we don’t offer one yet).

Search demand (DataForSEO, US monthly volumes, Apr 2026 export):

Cluster	Head term	Volume/mo
Ceremonial cacao	“ceremonial cacao”	8,100
	“best ceremonial cacao”	480
	“ceremonial cacao near me”	390 (high CPC, local-pack heavy — we’d skip)
Cacao nibs	“cacao nibs”	33,100
	“organic cacao nibs”	~1,900–2,900
Beans / origin	“raw cacao beans”	3,600
	“cacao beans for sale”	1,300
Wholesale (B2B)	“wholesale cacao” + variants	~200/term

Two readings we’d like pressure-tested: (a) the **ceremonial-cacao head term (8,100/mo) is contested and competitors are already bidding it** — capture play, likely expensive; (b) the **nibs cluster (33k+/mo) is much bigger and adjacent** — we carry nibs SKUs, but it’s a foods/commodity intent, not a ceremony intent, so conversion economics may be entirely different.

Brand guardrails (these are firm):

1. No paid influencer / creator endorsements — paid endorsement flattens the provenance story. Earned mentions are fine.
2. The brand voice is community/lineage-centered, not founder-personality marketing.
3. We're a DAO — every dollar of spend and revenue is publicly ledgered. The ads process must produce clean enough numbers to ledger.

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6. What we want your input on

We're trying to understand **the shape of the process**, not asking you to run campaigns. Specifically:

1. **Channel sequencing.** Given the demographic (Facebook-heavy) and the competitor behavior (Google search), where would you start — Meta prospecting, Google search capture, or both in parallel? What's the minimum viable channel mix to learn anything?
2. **Budget floor.** What monthly spend is the realistic minimum to get statistically meaningful signal on a $25–75 AOV product? How long should a test run before we judge it?
3. **Measurement stack.** For a static site + Stripe checkout (no app, no existing pixel infrastructure): what's the right minimal setup? (Meta Pixel + Conversions API? GA4? Server-side events from Stripe webhooks? Anything you'd skip at our scale?)
4. **KPI framework.** How should we define target CAC / ROAS given the repeat behavior above? First-order breakeven vs. LTV-payback — what's the right frame for a consumable with a ~1.5-month consumption cycle?
5. **Creative requirements.** What formats and how many variants do we realistically need to start on Meta? Is founder-shot/UGC-style sufficient, or does this category need produced assets? How fast should we expect to iterate?
6. **Entry offer / SKU strategy.** Would you lead paid traffic with the $10 bar (impulse price, 40% margin, tree + email capture, sold-out first run) and upsell to the $25 ceremonial bag — or lead with the higher-AOV ceremonial basket directly? Does the vintage / limited-run model (every year a new harvest, inherently scarce) change how you'd structure offers?
7. **Landing experience.** Send traffic to existing product pages, or build dedicated landers? Anything about our checkout flow you'd fix first (e.g. customer-paid shipping at $8.60 on a $25 item)?
8. **Process & people.** What does the operating cadence look like (weekly reviews? creative pipeline? budget reallocation rules)? At our stage, is this operator-run, fractional specialist, or agency work — and what would you watch for in each?
9. **Failure modes.** What are the classic ways a sub-$5k/month DTC ads program wastes its budget, and how do we pre-empt them?

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7. Appendix — links & sources

- Store: https://agroverse.shop
- Example product page: https://agroverse.shop/product-page/ceremonial-cacao-fazenda-santa-ana-2023-200g
- Farm provenance example: https://agroverse.shop/farms/oscar-bahia/index.html
- Partner network: https://agroverse.shop/partners/
- DAO transparency: https://truesight.me (treasury, ledgers, stats)
- Shipment ledgers: TrueSight DAO Main Ledger, "Shipment Ledger Listing" tab (18 managed ledgers, AGL0–AGL15 + program funds)
- Repeat-order evidence: agroverse.shop Stripe order notifications, Dec 25 2025 & May 29 2026 (customer details withheld here; available on request)
- Remote-onboarding evidence: The Way Home Shop email thread, Apr 24 – May 13, 2026
- Competitor research (this repo): `ceremonial_cacao_seo/brand_sales_drivers_report.md`, `ceremonial_cacao_seo/positioning_summary.md`, `ceremonial_cacao_seo/seo_keyword_strategy.md` (Feb–Mar 2026, Playwright site crawls of top-5 brands)
- Search-volume data (this repo): `output/dataforseo/AGROVERSE_POSITIONING_NONBRAND_BUYER_INTENT.md` (DataForSEO Keywords-for-Keywords export, Apr 2026, ~197 non-brand buyer-intent terms after blocklist)